INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #21 · FRIENDS AND BELONGING

“Nobody really likes me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Being left out, teased, or ignored, especially in childhood or adolescence, can plant the idea that we are unlikable. A few painful experiences can become a lens: a friend who does not text back means dislike, a quiet group means rejection. The belief then shapes behavior. We withdraw, wait to be chosen, or expect the worst, and that can reduce the connection we long for.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said to His disciples, “I have called you friends.” Scripture says, “There is a friend who stays closer than a brother,” and “A friend loves at all times.” God’s thoughts toward you are personal: “How precious to me are Your thoughts, O God, how vast is their sum!” and “The LORD your God is among you… He will rejoice over you with singing.” If the Creator delights in you, then you are not unlikable. Friendship takes time and risk, but the starting point is that you are already known and wanted by God.

> *“No longer do I call you servants, for a servant does not understand what his master is doing. But I have called you friends, because everything I have learned from My Father I have made known to you”* (John 15:15).

Also see

> “A man of many companions may come to ruin, but there is a friend who stays closer than a brother” (Proverbs 18:24).

> “A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity” (Proverbs 17:17).

> “The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing” (Zephaniah 3:17).

> “Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God” (Romans 15:7).

Common self-statements

- People only tolerate me.
- If I disappeared, nobody would notice.
- Everyone finds me boring or annoying.
- They are being nice out of pity.
- I will always be on the outside.
- There is something unlikable about me.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know what others think of me.
- Overgeneralizing: Treating a few rejections as proof that nobody likes me.
- Mental filter: Remembering rejections and forgetting kindnesses.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling disliked and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- What evidence do I have that someone likes me, even a little?
- Who has been kind to me or reached out?
- Where did I learn that I am unlikable?
- Am I rejecting people before they can reject me?
- What does God say about how He sees me?
- What is one small step toward connection I could take?

Truth summary

> I am not unlikable. Jesus calls me His friend, and God rejoices over me. Some people may not connect with me, but that is not a verdict on my worth. I can take small, steady steps toward friendship.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Friendship
- Loneliness
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love, For Others
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God's faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

What a Friend We Have in Jesus — Keith and Kristyn Getty
This classic hymn invites direct, honest prayer with the Savior who carries our burdens.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Nobody really likes me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Nobody really likes me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who has been kind to me?
- ☐ What evidence do I have that someone likes me?
- ☐ Where did I learn I am unlikable?
- ☐ Am I pulling away first?
- ☐ What does God say about me?
- ☐ What small step can I take?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus calls me a friend.
- ☐ God rejoices over me with singing.
- ☐ A few rejections do not define me.
- ☐ Friendship grows slowly.
- ☐ Some people do like me.
- ☐ I can take a step toward others.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **John 15:15**
  "No longer do I call you servants, for a servant does not understand what his master is doing. But I have called you friends, because everything I have learned from My Father I have made known to you."
- ☐ **Proverbs 18:24**
  "A man of many companions may come to ruin, but there is a friend who stays closer than a brother."
- ☐ **Zephaniah 3:17**
  "The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Signs of connection: Each day, write one kind word, text, or smile you received or gave.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, John 15:15 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus has called me His friend, so I am not unlikable.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Friendship" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List the evidence. Write names of people who have been kind or interested in you.
- ☐ Make a small reach. Send one message or invite one person for coffee.
- ☐ Catch the prediction. Write the thought "they will reject me" and test it afterward.
- ☐ Read John 15:15. Let it remind you who calls you friend.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Nobody really likes me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A connection made
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Nobody really likes me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, You call me friend. Heal the places where I have been rejected. Give me courage to reach out and eyes to see the people who care about me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.